



watering is needed, but fertilizer should be applied each year in midsummer after stalks have been harvested. In the fall, the ferny foliage will become strawlike and should be cut down.

HARVESTING

After two years, asparagus will be ready to harvest. In the third year, a light crop is taken in mid-spring, and subsequently full cropping can begin. Use a knife to slice stems free, taking care not to harm emerging spears nearby. Cut the stems 1 in (2.5 cm) below the soil surface when they reach about 5–7 in (13–18 cm) tall.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Asparagus beetle is the only serious pest. Treat infected plants with an appropriate insecticide or by picking off the beetles and larvae. Root diseases sometimes occur; fresh crowns must be planted on a new site. Slugs may also damage emerging spears.



Asparagus beetles strip plant foliage.